Historical source

Encyclopaedia Britannica scan, source row 217. Parse 3.5 extracted the text. Super 3.5 VL corrected it from an enlarged crop of each block. It can still contain recognition errors. Page headers, footers, and page numbers are removed.

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Continues an entry from an earlier page.

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the country in their time was entirely cleared, or di- sinitely divided ; the fields were surrounded by woods, not by hedges ; and if a considerable tract of improved land lay together, it still was not feperated into a num- ber of inclofures. The fubjects, therefore, proper to re- ceive this character, are those in which cultivation feems to have encroached on the wild, not to have subdued it ; as the bottom of a valley in corn, while the fides are ftil overgrown with wood ; and the outline of that wood indented by the tillage creeping more or less up the hill. But a glade of grass, thus circumstanced, does not peculiarly belong to the species that may occur in a park or pastoral farm ; in this, the paftures should rather border on a waste or a common : if large, they may be broken by fraggling bufhcs, thickets, or coppices ; and the scattered trees should be best with brambles and briers. All these are circumftances which improve the beauty of the place ; yet appear to be only remains of the wild, not intended for embellish- ment. Such interruptions must, however, be less fre- quent in the arable parts of the farm ; but there the opening may be divided into several lands, diflinguifh- ed, as in common fields, only by different forts of grain. These will sufficiently break the sameness of the space ; and tillage does not furnish a more pleasing feene, than such a space fo broken, if the extent be mo- derate, and the boundary beautiful.

As much wood is essential to the character, a spot may easily be found, where turrets rising above the covert, or some arches seen within it, may have the resemblance of a castle or an abbey. The partial concealment is almost necessary to both; for to accord with the age, the buildings must seem to be entire; the ruins of them belong to later days; the difficulty is, however, advantageous to them as objects; none can be imagined more picturesque, than a tower bosomed in trees, or a cluster appearing between the elms and the branches. But the superfluities of the times furnish other objects which are more within compass; hermitages were then real; foliary chapels were common; many of the springs of the country being deemed holy wells, were distinguished by little Gothic domes built over them; and every hamlet had its cross; even this, when perfect, set on a little rustic pillar, and that raised upon a base of circular steps, may in some scenes be considerable: if a situation can be found for a May-pole, whence it would not obtrude itself on every view, that also might not be improper; and an ancient church, however unwelcome it may be when it breaks into the design of a park or a garden, in such a farm as this would be a fortunate accident: nor would the old yew in the church-yard be indifferent; it would be a memorial of the times when it was useful.

Many other objects, figured on the manner of monitors, might perhaps upon recollection, occur; but these are simply sufficient for a place of considerable extent; and cottages must abound in every age and every country; they may therefore be introduced in different forms and positions. Large pieces of water are also particularly proper; and all the varieties of rills are confluent with every species of farm. From the concurrence of so many agreeable circumstances in this, be the force or the effect of the character what it may, a number of pleasing scenes may be exhibited ei- ther in a walk or riding, to be contrasted to those

which in another part of the place may be formed on Arcadian ideas ; or even to be substituted in their head, if they are omitted.

A part may also be free from either of these imitative characters, and laid out in a common simple farm. Some of the greatest beauties of nature are to be found in the fields, and attend an ordinary state of cultivation: wood and water may there be exhibited in several forms and dispositions; we may enlarge or divide the inclosures; and give them such shapes and boundaries as we please; every one may be an agreeable spot; together, they may compose beautiful views; the arable, the pasture, and the mead, may succeed one another; and now and then a little wild may be intermixed without impropriety; every beauty, in short, which is not unusual in an inclosed country, whether it arise from neglect or improvement, is here in its place.

The buildings, also, which are frequent in such a country, are often beautiful objects; the church and the mansion are considerable; the farm-yard itself, if an advantageous situation be chosen for it; if the ricks, and the barns, and the out-houes, are ranged with any deign to form them into groups, and if they are properly blended with trees; may be made a pic- turefque composition. Many of them may be detached from the group, and dispersed about the grounds; the dove-cote, or the dairy, may be feperated from the ret; they may be elegant in their forms, and pla- ced wherever they will have the best effect. A com- mon barn, accompanied by a clump, is sometimes pleasing at a

distance; a Dutch barn is fo when near; and an hay-stack is generally an agreeable circum- stance in any poftition. Each of these may be ingle; and besides these, all kinds of cottages are proper. Among fo many buildings, some may be converted to other purpofes than their contruction denotes; and, whatever be their exterior, may within be made agree- able retreats, for refreshment, indulgene, or shelter.

With such opportunities of improvement, even to decoration within itself, and with advantages of prospect into the country about it, a simple farm may undoubtedly be delightful. It will be particularly acceptable to the owner, if it be close to his park or his garden: the objects which constantly remind him of his rank, impose a kind of constraint; and he feels himself relieved, by retiring sometimes from the splendour of a seat into the simplicity of a farm: it is more than a variety of scene; it is a temporary change of situation in life, which has all the charms of novelty, ease, and tranquillity, to recommend it. A place, therefore, can hardly be deemed perfect, which is not provided with such a retreat. But if it be the whole of the place, it seems inadequate to the mansion: a visitor is disappointed; the master is dissatisfied; he is not sufficiently distinguished from his tenants; he misses the appendages incidental to his state and his fortune; and is hurt at the familiarity of his grounds with the country about them. A paddock is an ancient farm in a little above the common level; but even these, if brought close up at the door, set the house in a field, where it always appears to be neglected and naked. Some degree of polish and ornament is expected in its immediate environs; and a garden, though it be but a small one, should be interposed between the mansion and any species of farm.

Source record

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